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Medical debt is plaguing many here

More than 1 in 8 in Mass. face it despite coverage

By Jonathan Saltzman
GLOBE STAFF

Despite nearly universal health insurance coverage in Massachusetts, more than one in eight residents carry medical debt, according to a report released Thursday by a state agency.

The vast majority of those people were insured when bills started to pile up, said the study by the Center for Health Information and Analysis, which monitors the Massachusetts health care landscape. But many had insurance plans with high deductibles.

“Massachusetts prides itself on its near-universal health insurance coverage rate, but it’s a hollow victory when more than 12 percent of residents are incurring debt for their care,” said Lauren Peters, executive director of the center.

The study comes as Massachusetts officials are preparing for medical debt to potentially balloon amid federal policy changes that could lead to more uninsured and underinsured people. The state estimates that up to 300,000 recipients of Medicaid, the government insurer for the poor and disabled, could lose coverage due to new eligibility and work requirements, and the expiration of certain subsidies will make health insurance more expensive for people who purchase their own.

The consequences of such debt are far-reaching, said the study, causing people to forgo medical care and struggle to pay for food and housing.

In 2006, then-governor Mitt Romney signed

MEDICAL DEBT, Page A9

CDC now reflects RFK Jr. on autism

Webpage no longer says vaccines aren’t to blame

By Chelsea Cirruzzo, Helen Branswell, and Daniel Payne
STAT

WASHINGTON — The Centers for Disease Control and Prevention on Wednesday publicly reversed its stance that vaccines do not cause autism, over the objections of career staff and counter to years of scientific evidence.

A CDC webpage that previously said there’s no link between autism and vaccines was quietly updated to call that claim “not evidence based,” among other statements that are not factual.

The updated page did not go through normal scientific clearance, Daniel Jernigan, a top CDC leader who resigned in August, told STAT, citing conversations with CDC staff. Another person familiar with the situation, not authorized to speak publicly, also said that the CDC office that manages the page was not involved in the decision.

The former head of the CDC center that oversees immunization policy and implementation concurred.

“From my personal communications with folks, everyone was blindsided from the perspective of career scientists,” said Demetre Daskalakis, who was director of CDC’s National Center for Immunization and Respiratory Diseases until he quit in August at the same time as Jernigan.

The changes are the latest move by the federal health department, led by Robert F. Kennedy Jr., to sow doubt about childhood vac-

AUTISM, Page A8



The changes to the CDC website appear to violate a promise Robert F. Kennedy Jr. made during his confirmation hearing.

In split with Trump, Greene takes long view

May be staking her claim to MAGA with recent moves

By Sam Brodey
GLOBE STAFF

WASHINGTON — Representative Marjorie Taylor Greene’s dramatic fallout with President Trump risked becoming the beginning of the end of her political career.

Instead, the Georgia Republican could be pushing toward the start of something else: a new era in GOP

politics that is focused less on Trump and more on what comes after him.

By bucking Trump in pushing for the release of files about convicted sex offender Jeffrey Epstein — and then castigating her party for its handling of the federal government shutdown — Greene earned a furious rebuke from the president, who said he was withdrawing his endorsement of the “wacky” Greene.

But any real backlash — or an immediately heightened primary threat — hasn’t materialized in her district, which voted for the president by a nearly 37-point margin, and for

Greene by a 29-point margin, in 2024. In fact, Greene might have even expanded her support with her high-risk break from Trump.

“If anything, people here respect

► **Trump accuses Democratic lawmakers of “seditious behavior.” A6.**

that she speaks her mind,” said Ricky Hess, chairman of the GOP in Paulding County, in Greene’s district.

“Voters know she’s not afraid to challenge anyone when she feels strongly,” Hess added. “That independence is part of why she won in

the first place, and her core support hasn’t gone anywhere. If anything, I’ve seen some people who were on the fence about her come out in support of the issues she’s raising right now.”

Indeed, Epstein wasn’t the only fault line between Greene and Trump. During the government shutdown, she essentially sided with Democrats by urging the GOP to extend expiring Affordable Care Act premium subsidies. She has also torched Trump’s decision to expand visas for skilled labor with a new

GREENE, Page A6

CHENEY LAID TO REST



ABOVE: MATT ROURKE/ASSOCIATED PRESS LEFT: SAUL LOEB/AFP VIA GETTY IMAGES



A mix of Democrats and Republicans gathered to mourn former Vice President Dick Cheney on Thursday at Washington National Cathedral, including (from left), George W. and Laura Bush, Joe and Jill Biden, Kamala Harris, and Mike and Karen Pence. Above, Cheney’s daughter Liz walked by the casket after speaking. President Trump and Vice President JD Vance were not invited to the ceremony. **A2.**

‘It’s a symptom of our poor public records law that allows those in government agencies . . . to play games with the law.’

JUSTIN SILVERMAN, *First Amendment Coalition*

Email puts school district’s resistance on records in writing

By Christopher Huffaker
GLOBE STAFF

Kyle York has long had concerns about how business is done at Lexington Public Schools. Dissatisfied with how the district supported his daughter with dyslexia, York began requesting a series of records last April. Jumping off another parent’s research, he was soon seeking expense invoices that would explain, for example, how the administration spent tens of thousands of dollars at the Beauport Hotel in Gloucester.

The whole time, York felt Lexington officials were stonewalling his requests, or charging him exorbitant fees, hoping he would go away. An email he recently discovered and shared with the Globe shows, at least in one instance, his suspicions were

dead on.

“Can you over estimate the time that it would take you to compile/copy the invoices requested and let me know when you have a chance?” one district employee wrote in a May 12, 2025, email, which York obtained in a broader record release. “Hopefully, when I let [York] know the cost they will not want to do it.”

The request in question ended up getting fulfilled for free, rather than York having to pay an estimated \$1,000, as part of the same data release that the email was in. Lexington Superintendent Julie Hackett apologized to York after he notified her of the duplicitous email last month. But York and other residents have been assessed even high-

RECORDS, Page A9

Research on possible cancer cluster hampered by lack of funding

Residents of N.H. town want answers on chemicals

By Kate Selig
GLOBE STAFF

After the largest ground water contamination in New Hampshire history, a state-commissioned study released this fall found significantly elevated rates of kidney cancer in the town of Merrimack.

Residents fear that toxic “forever chemicals” are to blame. But to pin down a cause, the researchers need millions in funding. With federal dollars in flux, it’s unclear whether the final phase of research will be completed, leaving residents in the dark and policies to address pollutants on the table.

The chemicals, PFAS, are widespread in drinking water and have been linked to a range of adverse health effects, including certain cancers. The study in Merrimack puts the community on the brink of a rare chance to tie PFAS contamination to a cancer cluster, confirming suspicions that are often impossible to prove due to the limitations of science.

“Could this have happened just because I was drinking water?” asked Jon Duhaime, a lifelong Merrimack resident who was diagnosed with kidney cancer at 32.

Researchers from the state Department of Health and Human Services and Dartmouth College analyzed nearly three decades of cancer reg-

CANCER, Page A8

A state-appointed commission approved recommendations to increase tolerance, improve education about antisemitism, and monitor hate incidents. **B1.**

A US military delegation delivered a new draft proposal to end the war in Ukraine amid warnings any deal should not involve “capitulation.” **A3.**

“Wicked: For Good,” the movie adaptation of the second act of the “Wicked” musical, is here. Odie Henderson’s take, **G1.**



A higher degree

Friday: A bit milder. High 46-51. Low 40-45.

Saturday: More of the same. High 47-52. Low 31-36.

High tide: 11:33 a.m.

Sunrise: 6:42 Sunset: 4:17

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